

World Fine Dining — Stories, Recipes & Wine

Moroccan Tagine · Greek Kleftiko · Cochinillo · Paella · Rogan Josh · Peking Duck · Persian Saffron Lamb

Each dish includes the story behind it, a curated link to the best free recipe we've found, and a detailed wine pairing — with the food science that explains why it works. kazmicellars.com

Moroccan Lamb Tagine

Morocco

The tagine is both the dish and the conical clay vessel it cooks in — the cone traps steam and returns it as condensation, basting the meat continuously. Moroccan tagines are defined by the interplay of savoury and sweet: meat with dried fruit, olives with preserved lemons, spice with honey. Ras el hanout — the spice blend whose name means 'top of the shop' — can contain 20 or more spices. This is North Africa's greatest slow-cooked dish.

Serves	Prep	Difficulty	Best Season
6	30 min + 2 hrs 30 min cook	Medium	Autumn / Winter

FIND THE RECIPE

Source: RecipeTin Eats

Link: <https://www.recipetineats.com/lamb-tagine/>

Why: The ras el hanout spice blend is made from scratch — far superior to jar versions. Excellent balance of sweet and savoury, and clear guidance on getting the sauce to the right reduced consistency.

Tip: Make the ras el hanout from scratch at least once. The fragrance of freshly combined whole spices is incomparable.

WINE PAIRING

Primary: Southern Rhône — Gigondas or Vacqueyras (Grenache blend)

The warming spice, dried fruit sweetness, and lamb richness call for a wine with its own warm spice character. Grenache-based blends have cinnamon and dark fruit that mirror the tagine's palette.

Alternative: Dry Provence Rosé — Bandol or Côtes de Provence

A serious, dry rosé handles the tagine's sweetness and spice with elegance. The fruit freshness and cool minerality cuts through the richness of the lamb fat.

Heavily spiced dishes demand wine with enough fruit and warmth to match. The preserved lemon adds acidity — the wine benefits from fruit weight rather than high tannin. Avoid very tannic reds, which clash with the tagine's sweetness.

Lamb Kleftiko

Greece

Kleftiko means 'stolen lamb.' The Klepths — Greek mountain bandits fighting Turkish occupation — would steal sheep and cook them in sealed underground pits to hide the smoke and smell. Today the technique is the parchment parcel: marinated lamb wrapped tightly with potatoes and vegetables, slow-roasted until the steam inside does all the work. Opening the parcel at the table, releasing the steam, is one of dining's great theatrical moments.

Serves	Prep	Difficulty	Best Season
6	20 min + overnight marinating + 3 hrs 30 min cook	Easy	Spring / Easter

FIND THE RECIPE

Source: The Mediterranean Dish

Link: <https://www.themediterraneandish.com/kleftiko-greek-lamb-in-parchment/>

Why: The most authentic English-language version available. The Mediterranean Dish specialises in regional Mediterranean cooking and handles the Greek tradition with respect.

Tip: The overnight marinade is non-negotiable. The lemon, garlic, and oregano need time to penetrate the meat. Make it the night before, then the day's cooking is mostly passive.

WINE PAIRING

Primary: Xinomavro — Naoussa PDO or Amynteon PDO (Greece)

Xinomavro is Greece's greatest red grape — high acid, high tannin, with dried tomato, olive, and herb notes that mirror the kleftiko's aromatics almost note for note.

Alternative: Agiorgitiko — Nemea PDO (Peloponnese, Greece)

Softer and richer than Xinomavro — dark cherry, plum, and chocolate with moderate tannin. More approachable and equally Greek.

Greek lamb has a specific herbal quality from the mountain thyme and oregano in the diet of free-range Greek sheep. Native Greek varieties share this herbal DNA — it's a pairing that can't be replicated with French or Italian grapes.

Cochinillo Asado

Castile, Spain (Segovia)

At Sobrino de Botín in Madrid, the world's oldest restaurant (founded 1725, Guinness certified), roast suckling pig is carved using the edge of a ceramic plate — demonstrating that the skin is so crisp and the meat so tender that no knife is required. The piglet must be no more than 21 days old. The secret is simplicity: lard, water, salt, and a very hot oven. This is Castilian cooking at its most elemental — the dish that has not changed in 300 years.

Serves	Prep	Difficulty	Best Season
6-8	15 min + 2 hrs cook	Hard	Autumn / Winter

FIND THE RECIPE

Source: Serious Eats

Link:	https://www.serious eats.com/cochinillo-asado-segovian-roast-suckling-pig
Why:	<i>The definitive English-language recipe — includes the science behind the skin crisping and the history of the dish. The plate-carving test is described and explained.</i>
Tip:	<i>The pig must come to room temperature before roasting — 2 full hours. The skin must be completely dry before larding and seasoning.</i>

WINE PAIRING

Primary:	Ribera del Duero Crianza — Tinto Fino (Tempranillo)
	<i>Castile's greatest wine for Castile's greatest dish. Ribera del Duero Crianza has the structure and dark fruit to match the rich pork, while oak aging adds vanilla and spice that complements the crackling.</i>
Alternative:	Rioja Reserva — Tempranillo + Graciano + Garnacha
	<i>Rioja Reserva brings American oak vanilla and dried cherry character. The aging has softened the tannins to match the tender pork perfectly.</i>
<i>Suckling pig's skin requires a wine that refreshes the palate between bites — the fat content of the skin is substantial. Tempranillo's natural acidity and moderate tannin does this work without overwhelming the delicate meat beneath.</i>	

Paella Valenciana

Valencia, Spain

The most misrepresented dish in Spanish cuisine. In Valencia, paella contains rabbit, chicken, green beans, and butter beans — no seafood, no chorizo. Adding seafood to Paella Valenciana is as incorrect as adding cream to carbonara. Developed by rice field workers in the 19th century using what was nearby: local rabbit, snails, and the flat rice grown around the Albufera lagoon. The socarrat — the caramelised crust at the bottom of the pan — is the most prized part.

Serves	Prep	Difficulty	Best Season
6	30 min + 45 min cook	Hard	Year-round

FIND THE RECIPE

Source:	Serious Eats
Link:	https://www.serious eats.com/the-best-paella
Why:	<i>The most detailed English-language paella guide available. Covers the pan specification, the socarrat technique, and why the rice must never be stirred after adding.</i>
Tip:	<i>Use a genuine paella pan — the wide, shallow shape is essential for the evaporation and socarrat formation. No socarrat, no paella.</i>

WINE PAIRING

Primary:	Rioja Blanco — White Rioja (Viura / Macabeo, barrel-aged)
	<i>Aged White Rioja is Valencia's most interesting pairing. The Viura grape's oxidative, vanilla-scented, nutty character complements the saffron and roasted rabbit.</i>
Alternative:	Valencian Rosado — Monastrell rosé from DO Valencia

A dry, serious rosé from Valencia's own Monastrell grape — the regional wine with the regional dish.

Paella presents a complexity challenge: meat, saffron, and rosemary in one dish. Whites work because they don't compete with the saffron's delicate perfume. The socarrat adds toasty character that echoes aged white wines beautifully.

Rogan Josh

Kashmir, India / Persia

Rogan Josh arrived in Kashmir with the Mughal emperors from Persia. The name means 'cooked in oil at high intensity' or 'red heat.' The dish's deep scarlet colour comes not from chili heat but from Kashmiri chili (a mild, brilliantly coloured variety). True Rogan Josh contains no tomatoes. The warmth comes from cardamom, cloves, and fennel; the depth from slow-cooked lamb and yogurt. One of India's most sophisticated curry traditions.

Serves	Prep	Difficulty	Best Season
6	30 min + 2 hrs cook	Medium	Autumn / Winter

FIND THE RECIPE

Source: RecipeTin Eats

Link: <https://www.recipetineats.com/rogan-josh/>

Why: Exceptional sourcing of authentic spices with clear substitutes for harder-to-find ingredients. The technique of 'bhunao' — cooking until the oil separates from the masala — is explained clearly with visual cues.

Tip: Toast the whole spices in ghee before anything else — this step builds the fragrant foundation the entire dish depends on.

WINE PAIRING

Primary: Riesling Spätlese — Mosel, Germany (off-dry)

Riesling is the world's greatest wine for spiced meat dishes. Off-dry Spätlese has enough residual sweetness to balance the chili warmth, enough acidity to cut through the yogurt richness, and floral character that harmonises with Kashmiri spice.

Alternative: Gewurztraminer — Alsace (off-dry)

Gewurztraminer's exotic lychee, rose water, and ginger character is one of wine's great accidental matches for Indian spicing.

Heavily spiced dishes famously challenge wine pairing. Avoid very tannic reds (tannin amplifies chili heat) and very oaky wines (oak and spice clash). Lean toward aromatic whites with slight sweetness, high acidity, or both. The sweetness in off-dry wines doesn't compete with spice — it calms it.

Peking Duck

Beijing, China (Imperial era)

Peking Duck was served to the Emperor of China before Europe had learned to roast a chicken properly. The process was developed in Beijing's Imperial kitchens and requires four distinct stages over 24 hours: blanching, glazing, air-drying, and roasting. The skin is separated from the fat before cooking so it crisps without grease. Served with mandarin pancakes, hoisin, cucumber, and scallions — eating with your hands is required.

Serves	Prep	Difficulty	Best Season
4	24 hrs + 1 hr 30 min cook	Hard	Year-round

FIND THE RECIPE

Source: The Woks of Life

Link: <https://thewoksoflife.com/peking-duck-roasted/>

Why: The most authoritative Chinese cooking resource in English. This family-run site has spent years perfecting the Peking Duck recipe for home ovens, with excellent guidance on the air-drying technique.

Tip: The air-drying step is non-negotiable — at least 8 hours, preferably overnight uncovered in the fridge. The skin must feel like dry parchment before roasting.

WINE PAIRING

Primary: Oregon Pinot Noir — Willamette Valley

Pinot Noir is Peking Duck's greatest western wine partner. Delicate red fruit, earthiness, and silky tannins complement the duck's richness without overwhelming the hoisin's sweetness.

Alternative: Off-dry Riesling — Mosel Spätlese or Alsace Demi-Sec

The hoisin sauce has significant sweetness — an off-dry Riesling harmonises with it rather than fighting it, while the acidity cuts through the duck fat.

Duck fat is sweet and rich. The hoisin adds soy-based umami and sweetness. Together they need a wine that is either fruity enough to harmonise (Pinot Noir, off-dry Riesling) or acidic enough to cleanse (sparkling wine). Dry, tannic reds taste harsh against the hoisin's sweetness.

Persian Saffron Lamb with Tahdig

Iran / Persia

Persian cuisine may be the world's oldest continuously practised fine dining tradition. The Persian kitchen's defining principles are balance: sweet with sour (barberries, pomegranate), fragrant with savoury (saffron, rose petals, turmeric). Tahdig — the golden, crispy rice crust at the bottom of the pot — is the most coveted part of any Persian meal. When the pot is inverted and the tahdig emerges intact, there is applause.

Serves	Prep	Difficulty	Best Season
6	30 min + 2 hrs cook + 45 min rice	Medium	Year-round

FIND THE RECIPE

Source: The Mediterranean Dish

Link: <https://www.themediterraneandish.com/persian-lamb-stew/>

Why: The most accessible English-language guide to Persian cooking technique — including the critically important tahdig method with clear instructions for achieving the perfect golden crust without burning.

Tip: *The tahdig takes practice. The first time, check it frequently. The smell of gentle toasting is your signal — it should smell nutty, not smoky.*

WINE PAIRING

Primary: Gewurztraminer — Alsace Grand Cru

Saffron, rose water, and barberries create one of wine's most exotic flavour profiles. Gewurztraminer's own rose, lychee, and ginger aromatics mirror the dish at a molecular level — both contain the same terpene compounds.

Alternative: Viognier — Condrieu or Northern Rhône

Viognier's apricot, honeysuckle, and stone fruit character has similar floral generosity to Gewurztraminer. A subtler approach to the same pairing principle.

Saffron and Gewurztraminer share specific aromatic compounds — linalool and geraniol. This is not coincidence, it is biochemistry. When the wine and the spice share molecules, the pairing achieves a resonance beyond mere compatibility.